

I insist that the transmission of the NT Text was in fact predominantly normal, based on historical evidence. Part I above lists and discusses that evidence, but here is a thumbnail sketch:

1. The authors of the NT books believed they were writing Scripture;
2. The Apostles recognized that their colleagues were writing Scripture;
3. The ‘Church Fathers’ of the I and II centuries regarded the NT writings as Scripture;
4. The NT writings were used along with the OT by the Christian congregations from very early on;
5. The early Christians were concerned about the purity of the NT Text.
6. What regions started out with the Autographs? Aegean area (18-24), Rome (2-7), Palestine (0-3), Egypt (0).
7. Where was the Church strongest during the II and III centuries? Asia Minor and the Aegean area.
8. Where was Greek used most and longest? Aegean area and Asia Minor.
9. What are the implications of Diocletian’s campaign and the Donatist movement?

I submit that the evidence is clear to the effect that the transmission was in fact predominantly normal.

So what sort of a picture may we expect to find in the surviving witnesses, given the understanding that the history of the transmission of the New Testament Text was predominantly normal? We may expect a broad spectrum of copies, showing minor differences due to copying mistakes but all reflecting one common tradition. The simultaneous existence of abnormal transmission in the earliest centuries would result in a sprinkling of copies, helter-skelter, outside of that main stream. The picture would look something like the following figure.¹

¹ The history of the place where Codex W was found suggests that it must have been copied before AD 200, which would put the Byzantine Text in the second century, since it shows Byzantine influence.